



WOMEN AND MONEY

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Urban Indian women are no longer cash busters, but money makers too, outliving the stereotype to push their way to economic independence

■ By Ashima Goyal

What does an urban Indian woman want? A sound education, a smooth career, glamour and all the perks associated with an independent income. Barriers have been broken and glass ceilings have been shattered. She has carved careers in businesses where women rarely used to venture. Individual success stories have become an inspiration for others. In 2004, South Asia had the highest number of women holding top positions, with Indian women cornering 14 per cent of senior business positions.

Yet there is a paradox. South Asian women's share in employment remains the lowest in the world—17.6 per cent compared to the world average of 42 in 2004. The female employment rate in this region was 40.7 compared to 68.6 in North America. Only about 16 per cent of urban Indian women work for a living and only a quarter of the number actually have some control over their earnings. A number of poor women, especially in rural areas, work for a pittance. There are geographical inequalities too. In better-off states, fewer women work though the number of urban working women is higher, evident in various north-eastern and southern states. Though the country has been witnessing some improvement

in the scenario, the pace at which this is happening is quite slow.

To understand what is going on in the world of women, one needs to understand two trends. First, women lost power and position in agrarian societies, which continued during the early stages of industrialisation. And second, knowledge-based economies enabled by new technologies suit their requirements and offer rapid advancement. Since India's diversity embraces both worlds, its women benefit from the second but continue to suffer from the first.

Trends indicate that female labour force participation, and therefore their economic power, follows a U-curve with industrial development. Fewer

women take up white-collar jobs in the initial stages, but their participation rises as more service sector jobs become available. This intensifies as knowledge-based economies of the third wave undergo a technological U-turn. Modern Internet and communication technologies have the potential to reverse the advantage that development gave to work outside the home. These technologies allow housework to be combined with distance working or flexible job timings, making it easier for women to resume work, if they are forced to interrupt it.

But technology is still seen as a male domain. This perception is made worse by the loss of power that women

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